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PROFILE



No water in the oasis: the Chilean Spring of 2019–2020

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ABSTRACT

We analyse the Chilean Spring of 2019–2020 – the fiercest social outburst in Chile during the last three decades. After discussing the combined role of long-standing grievances, political attitudes, and cultural change in triggering the outburst, we study the interplay among peaceful and violent protests and criminal activity. We argue that brutal police repression and governmental mismanagement contributed to deepening the crisis once it exploded. We conclude by describing the attempts of the political class to cope with the crisis and speculate about its potential political consequences, especially for the Chilean party system.

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On 9 October 2019 President Sebastián Piñera declared that Chile was a ‘true oasis with a stable democracy,’ favourably comparing the country to a ‘Latin America in turmoil’ (Cooperativa, 2019). The Chilean oasis would turn out to be an illusion, however. On October 19, what started out as student-led fare-dodging protests against a fare increase in the Santiago metro evolved into a wave of peaceful demonstrations and violent riots and lootings across the country. The ‘social outburst’ (*estallido social*, as it came to be known), or ‘Chilean Spring’, has resulted in more than twenty deaths and thousands of wounded civilians and security agents. A combination of concessions, reforms, and repression has so far been unable to defuse the gravest socio-political crisis since the country’s return to democracy in 1990.

This profile article attempts to describe and explain the protests in Chile – which are receding but still ongoing as we finish this piece in mid-January 2020. The first section discusses their explanatory factors, emphasizing the role played by grievances, political attitudes, and cultural change. The second section explores its protest dynamics: its tactics, actors, and the relationship between mobilization and repression. The final section offers some tentative conclusions about its political outcomes. We use academic references but also resort to news media, public opinion surveys carried out during the outburst, and our own observations of the mobilizations occurring in the cities of Santiago and Temuco.

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Understanding the causes¹

When asked about the causes of the protests, government authorities have commented that they ‘did not see it coming’ (Rodríguez, 2019). However, experts on Chilean politics and society have been studying its causes for years. Applying Schussman and Soule (2005) threefold typology of explanations associated with protest participation – biographical availability, structural availability, and political engagement – is useful to systematize and understand the causes of the Chilean Spring. First, biographical availability has played a role: protest participation is marked by the presence of university students with left-wing inclinations, as indicated by a CCC-based survey to demonstrators (Núcleo de Sociología Contingente, 2019). However, the movement clearly appeals to the general population: the most visible demands include miscellaneous issues such as improvement in pensions, health care reform, better salaries, and a new constitution: issues that extend well beyond the social and material interests of university students.

Second, structural availability has not been as important, at least in the usual sense. Indeed, social movement organizations (SMOs) have played a marginal role, which is surprising given their centrality in the protest campaigns of the past fifteen years (Somma & Medel, 2019). Initially, few organizations and leaders were visible; since early November a ‘Social Unity Front’ (*Mesa de Unidad Social*), made up of student and labour unions and other SMOs, has been organizing strikes, meeting and marches. The Front, however, does not have the same convening and negotiating power of SMOs in the past. In a country with high levels of internet use, SMO leadership seems to be partially replaced by the ‘weak ties’ of social media, which provide alternative venues for expression and activism.

The most convincing explanations, therefore, have to do with protestors’ political engagement and political grievances associated with the neoliberal socio-economic model inherited from the Pinochet dictatorship (Somma, 2017). This model privileges the private sector in welfare provision, resulting in a highly criticised, privatized pension system, and segmented education and healthcare, with lower-quality public services for the majority and expensive private ones for the well-off. Market-based inequalities have been politicized since the return to democracy (Roberts, 2016), as expectations of social mobility and welfare collided with the exclusionary nature of the system until they reached a tipping point with the fare increase on October 18. In fact, distributive justice is an important predictor of protest participation in Chile (Castillo, Palacios, Joignant, & Tham, 2015). One of the most oft-repeated slogans in the demonstrations is ‘It’s not 30 pesos, it’s 30 years.’

This account based on grievances, although valid, needs to be complemented with other explanations (see Somma, Bargsted, Disi, & Medel, 2019). First, the Chilean political system has become increasingly elitist and detached from society (Bargsted & Maldonado, 2018), as reflected in declining turnout rates and weakened linkages between social movement and partisan organizations (Disi, 2018). Few of those who protest in Chile do vote, and among youngsters, the pattern of protesting but not voting is very common (Sepúlveda, Istúriz, & Pérez, 2019).

Rapid cultural change has also compounded the effects of unequal capitalist development on popular discontent. Traditional hierarchies based on gender, sexual orientation, ethnic status, and age are becoming increasingly contested. Relevant precedents include the conflict between the indigenous Mapuche of southern Chile and the government for

increased recognition and autonomy, and the wave of feminist protests that swept through college campuses in 2018. The current mobilizations combine signs and chants about pensions, salaries, and debt with emblems of these groups, including LGBTQ pride flags and indigenous Andean and Mapuche *wiphala* and *wenufoye* flags, respectively, which are used by both indigenous and non-indigenous demonstrators as counter-hegemonic emblems (Blair, 2019). The most noteworthy example is the feminist ‘A rapist on your way’ (*un violador en tu camino*) flashmob criticizing the Chilean state’s treatment of women, which has been replicated by thousands of women across the globe (McGowan, 2019).

Lastly, in a cultural climate encouraging public transparency during the last decade, more attentive judicial and journalist entrepreneurs have uncovered a series of scandals involving the economic, political, military and religious elites. This translated into historically low levels of popular trust towards elites and institutions. As traditional sources of legitimation recede, socioeconomic, ethnic, and gender inequalities have become even more unbearable.

Protest dynamics in the Chilean Spring

Protests during the Chilean Spring are complex and varied. They have comprised pacific, disruptive, and openly violent tactics, which reinforce each other and interact with governmental actions and other political events.

In mid-October, police presence in metro stations after the first evasions only encouraged more massive evasions by non-students, leading to clashes with the police. On October 19, after clandestine groups completely burned twenty metro stations and peaceful protests burgeoned across Chile, President Piñera decreed a state of emergency and a curfew in most of the country. Instead of bringing peace, the emergency measures spurred a wave of lootings affecting supermarkets, stores and warehouses in many cities.

Piñera reacted by announcing the suspension of the subway fare increase, and promising to push for increases in pensions, higher minimum wages and new taxes to the rich. However, on a national broadcast on October 21, he also claimed that Chile was waging war against a powerful, criminal, and relentless foe, angering multitudes of peaceful protestors. Likewise, Defense Minister Alberto Espina asked Chileans to return to normal life, a challenging request for a country engulfed by violence, with a collapsed public transport system, and with millions unable to purchase basic goods due to lootings.

On October 25, around 1.2 million people demonstrated peacefully and festively on Plaza Baquedano (Santiago’s center) – the largest demonstration in Chilean history. Similar events took place in the rest of the country. Under the banner of ‘Chile woke up’, these demonstrations cut across age, socioeconomic and ideological groups. Slogans mostly expressed socioeconomic grievances, Chilean and Mapuche flags abounded, and political party flags were almost absent – a telling sign of the lack of party mobilization behind the protests. The political class applauded the demonstrations and legitimated their claims. In the following days, the government promised additional measures regarding wages and prices, the cabinet was partially reshuffled, and Piñera suspended the emergency measures.

Yet things were far from calming down. Since lootings were not abating, on early November Piñera announced harsher security measures, increasing sanctions for making barricades and looting, and giving new powers to police forces.

Complex repertoires

The protest repertoire of the Chilean Spring has ranged from peaceful actions to violent tactics to criminal behaviors. Peaceful protests include massive marches, concentrations, and pot-bangings. Improvised town meetings (*cabildos*) on streets, squares and municipal buildings have helped citizens to cope with the crisis and to seek solutions. Heavily symbolic protests have also occurred: musicians have released new songs denouncing repression and violence; others have nostalgically reissued songs dating from the 1970s.

In a country already used to massive peaceful protests, what has intimidated political elites the most is the steadiness and massiveness of violent civilian actions. First, the attacks on and burning of metro stations probably caused the largest material losses and disruption to Santiago. Given the sophisticated logistics needed to burn a metro station, observers suggested they were orchestrated by ‘professional’ criminals.

Second, civilian-police clashed at the edge of peaceful demonstrations have also become common. Crowds of hooded individuals have coordinated flexibly for the different tasks involved in the attacks: gathering stones, preparing Molotov cocktails, and placing them close to another group who throws them at the police; preparing a mix of water and baking soda for combating teargases; making barricades; mounting Viking-style defense lines with makeshift shields, and advancing with guttural chants towards the police. Some use laser pointers against police tanks, while medical volunteers remain at the sidelines to provide care to wounded demonstrators. These ‘first line’ protestors – as they are called – eventually detached from peaceful protests, arising each day at central city locations during the evenings (Claude, 2020).

Third, lootings of supermarkets and grocery stores also spread rapidly after October 18, creating scarcity of basic consumption goods in low-income neighborhoods. Organized groups gathered looters and coordinated their actions against specific targets at certain days and times. To maximize their booty, some looters used cars – sometimes very expensive ones, suggesting the operation of drug gangs. Yet opportunistic bystanders also took their share. Some left stores with looted TV sets only to be assaulted by armed gangs. Looted goods were sometimes resold to individuals or in informal street markets; others were distributed by drug gangs in lower-class neighborhoods in clientelistic exchanges. Because the exhausted police forces were controlling the crowds and first-liners, the cost of looting decreased, attracting regular criminals to the point that other types of crimes reportedly decreased (La Tercera, 2019, November 23).

To this we should add the less violent but very disruptive events in early January 2020, in which middle-school students sabotaged the application of the national standardized test required for entering the university system. About 13% of those registered to take the test could not do it (Díaz, 2020).

Repression

Police forces reacted brutally, causing fear, anger and consternation in the population, and radicalizing protestors. Repression included shooting demonstrators with pellets in

their faces and torsos, teargassing health centers and university campuses, staging violent raids in lower-class neighborhoods, and blocking emergency teams attempting to rescue wounded demonstrators. Repression targeted not only those engaged in violent or criminal activities but also peaceful demonstrators and bystanders, sometimes resulting in deaths or severe wounds (Human Rights Watch, 2019, November 26). Piñera's decision to take the armed forces to the streets evoked in the oldest Chileans painful memories about the dictatorship, while the youngest generations were the ones who reacted more vehemently against militarization.

Police shootings and teargassing have partially or totally blinded hundreds, to the point that activists in international summits have approached Chilean authorities with one eye covered. Testimonies of victims and videos of police repression circulate widely and quickly, causing widespread condemnation of police actions, and blaming the government for not controlling it. Domestic human rights organizations have filed hundreds of complaints, and denounced beatings, humiliations, tortures and sexual abuses (McDonald, 2019).

The government claimed these were isolated incidents meriting investigation, and police authorities added that many testimonies were exaggerated or fake. Several international organizations – including the United Nations, Human Rights Watch, and the Inter-American Commission on Human Rights – sent teams to Chile, which interviewed victims and observed citizen-police interactions. Their reports condemned police practices and suggested urgent measures to rectify them. In early December, Congress successfully passed a constitutional accusation against Andrés Chadwick, Interior Minister until October 28, due to his political responsibility in human rights violations. On December 12, several left-wing parties also attempted to accuse Piñera for the same reasons, but this accusation did not prosper, though the votes in the Lower House were almost split in half.

The constitutional promise

A breakthrough took place on November 15, as the crisis was threatening not only the government but the whole political class. After hectic discussions, almost all political parties signed an agreement that set a route to replace the current Pinochet-era constitution. In April 2020, an 'entry plebiscite' will ask citizens whether they approve or reject the elaboration of a new constitution, and whether it should be written by a constitutional assembly or a mixed assembly composed of elected delegates and current legislators. If 'approve' wins, the delegates will be elected via popular vote in October 2020. Lastly, in 2021 citizens will vote to approve or reject the constitutional text proposed by the assembly through an 'exit plebiscite'.

The November 15 agreement reduced the massiveness of peaceful demonstrations but did not abate violent incidents in subsequent weeks. As of mid-January, however, violence has decreased and the country is entering to some extent a new state of 'normality' – although disruptive protests continue taking place in city centers on a daily basis.

Consequences of the Chilean Spring: some tentative conclusions

The Chilean Spring not only revealed the enormous social discontent with the neoliberal socioeconomic model, but also challenged the political system. Arguably, the most threatened institutions are political parties. According to a survey conducted a few

weeks after its outbreak, political parties and Congress currently have the lowest levels of approval; people even declare to have more trust in the President and the police (Centro Microdatos, 2019). The fact that demonstrations were not lead by parties and actually shunned them, is clear evidence that politicians are one the most important targets of the movement.

In fact, the current social crisis might lead to a collapse of the party system, understood as a systemic change where established parties cease to be electorally relevant. This opens room for outsiders to gain influence and for the emergence of populist leaders who can erode liberal democracy.

Then, how likely is that the Chilean party system will collapse? The political establishment has reasons to be optimistic but also cautious. Most importantly, parties have not become paralyzed. On November 27 Congress members unanimously approved a 50% reduction of their salaries and other allowances, which has been a long-lasting, symbolic demand (Universidad del Desarrollo, 2019). Right-wing parties have also become more flexible in their legislative agenda, halting a series of bills that were in the government's original program, and approving other laws promoted by left-wing parties such as tax increases and reduction in working hours. Likewise, the fact that a majority of parties coordinated to sign an agreement for a new constitution is a clear signal that the political class is set to survive the crisis.

On the other hand, levels of partisan polarization among political elites are escalating. Call-outs and public shamming in social media between rival political actors, particularly deputies and senators, have become increasingly common. Members of far-Left parties have constantly deplored the constitutional agreement and called centre-Left and centrist legislators traitors of the people. In the same vein, the capacity of political parties to connect and establish linkages with mobilized civil society is rather limited.

The events during the next months will show if the measures adopted were enough to avoid the collapse. A decisive factor will be voter turnout in the plebiscites in April and (eventually) October 2020. Massive participation could restore some legitimacy to the political system and give political parties respite. Some studies suggest that those who participate in social movements tend to increase their sense of civic duty in regard to voting (Galais, 2014). One could expect, therefore, an important increase in electoral turnout based on the high rates of protest participation. The absence of a clear leadership within the movement makes communication with the political class difficult, but the organization of local *cabildos* as well as the increasing prominence of the Social Unity Front (*Mesa de Unidad Social*) may generate communicating vessels. The events in the coming months will be crucial for the medium and long term survival of parties and, eventually, of Chilean democracy, at least as we currently know it.

Note

1. This section elaborates on Somma et al. (2019).

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